



ON THE WRITE LINE

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RANJI TROPHY MATCH FEES NEEDS TO BE DOUBLED

With a **slab system** of more fees for every 10 matches played, not many will make themselves unavailable as there would be good money playing first-class cricket too.

What a wallop, what great fun to watch a young India team demolish an England team that had arrived in India with the usual 'we are doing you a favour' attitude that brings a smirk on the faces of those Indian officials who go to receive them at various airports.

The Aussies have been invariably better, looking to adapt themselves to the culture and not look down their noses at us natives. It also helps that the Aussies recognise a golden goose when they see one, and the IPL is certainly a humongous golden goose.

Not only do Aussie players, some so memorably described by Kevin Pietersen as second or third-grade cricketers, go for astronomical amounts, but there are also Aussie coaches, physios, trainers, and anybody who is their golf and beer buddy in the IPL coaching staff, making more money than they do at home.

Not to mention the commentators, where sometimes it feels more like the Australian Premier League than the Indian Premier League. The Aussies are likeable and don't have the supercilious attitude that the Poms generally have. That perhaps explains why the acrimony that was seen between the Indian and Australian teams has vanished almost entirely, even though the intensity of the contests between the countries hasn't reduced one bit.

That is also the reason why the England and Indian players get into verbal skirmishes so

often when they are playing against each other. Not a lot of England players are picked in the IPL, mainly because they can be withdrawn by their Board anytime for a preparation camp or something, which leaves the franchises in a lurch.

Some of them can't stomach the fees for which some of the Indian players are bought and compare their achievements at the international level when the IPL auction dynamics can be so volatile and hard to explain or even understand. So you see more lip in the India-England encounters than in any other India match. That's why the pleasure of beating England is always greater.

When Ben Stokes' team came to India, there was a buzz around it as they had started to play a brand of aggressive batting that the British media dubbed Bazball. This was because the new coach Brendon McCullum's nickname is Baz. He encouraged the players to always go in with a positive mindset and to keep at it, irrespective of the result. The batting thus became ultra-aggressive, with players encouraged to hit sixes and fours with a dot ball as the least preferred option. Stokes wanted his players to play like rock stars, whatever that means, and with England beginning to win games, the fans and the media were euphoric.

There's no doubt that the batting was exciting to watch with the way the scoreboard rattled along. They even scored more than 500 runs in a day in Pakistan and then went on to win all the Test matches played there.